

7. They have excellent communication skills

It is often said that better innovators are not better communicators, which in my opinion is just a red-herring. For any innovation to succeed, it must get communicated well at all stages and to everyone. So, checking for excellent communication skills is going to be highly important. See how the candidate responds when you challenge their ideas and how they convince or try to convince you.

8. Be okay with outside-sector experience

This point is perhaps one of the most counterintuitive ones on the list. Most people would think that having industry experience is a plus as that can help in innovating further. However, in my experience, it often backfires.

Institutional blindness is a real thing. It means that once someone has stayed in a particular industry for a long time, they often develop an ability to ignore the most obvious things, which is often detrimental to the innovation. Institutional blindness may be useful when it comes to speed, efficiency, and productivity. However, specific to innovation, it works against that.

9. They are good at adapting

Adaptability is an important trait in general, and it is even more important in the innovation game. The ability to respond to continuously changing situations and unexpected outcomes is the key to running successful innovation projects. Why not change your hiring methodology and see how people adapt to your process. That itself will filter a few candidates.

For example, instead of following a traditional hiring process of tests and interviews, do something different like running a contest or asking them to do something. Put the candidates in a novel scenario and ask them to make decisions. When you change the hiring methodology, only those who are good at adapting will excel and thrive. Rest will fall off eventually and make it easier for you to select.

10. They are more curious and less judgmental

Curiosity is often the beginning of

the innovation journey. If someone is judgmental and has already made up their mind, they are unlikely to investigate the matter further. And if that is the case, you are not going to see anything innovative.

On the contrary, curiosity often leads to the quest to know more and find out 'Why?' This quest then can result in deeper dive into the root causes of the matter at hand, or it may pose a 'Why not?' question. Both ways, it leads to innovation. Hire curious people for innovation and avoid judgemental ones.

11. Their resume most likely has a lot but can be confusing

Over the last two decades, I have noticed that most (or almost all) innovators have quite a non-linear career path. That often means that the traditional resume format does not do any justice when documenting that path. Suppose you come across a slightly off resume, which does not look like a traditional one; probe further.

You may be dealing with a cross-functionally experienced person. Although their career path looks non-linear and does not make sense at first glance, talking to them can often give you a better perspective. In most cases, they can draw a connecting line between all those experiences. And that can help you make the decision.

12. They are good at problem-solving but better at problem finding

Yes, problem-solving is a commonly revered skill for all cadre of employees. And when you deal with well-defined problems, that's all you need from someone. However, finding better problems to solve is becoming a forgotten skill. When you have someone who can find better problems to solve, it can open up a new potential opportunity for your business. It may help you tap into a completely new market, which can be a serious advantage for your business.

Testing a candidate for problem-finding ability is relatively easier. Of course, you want a meaningful problem finder who is willing to solve the problem too, not a complainer who finds faults but does nothing to fix them.

13. Avoid specialists; prefer more synthesists

If you ask someone, "What is the opposite of a specialist?" You will most likely hear, "A generalist." And that is incorrect. The real opposite of a specialist is synthesist. Specialists are good at breaking down things and working on them at a deeper level. On the other hand, synthesists are good at combining things and looking at the big picture.

The success of meaningful innovation is in defining its higher-level context in which your innovative product or solution will eventually operate. Only synthesists can see the big picture and explain how a particular innovation fits a bigger system or situation. It also means that synthesists can often connect the dots and derive innovation from different fields. More often than not, innovation is less about original ideas and more about original combinations.

14. They know what they don't know

'Know it all' people do not make a good fit for innovation teams. This point is a corollary to being more curious and less judgmental. When people are self-aware, they know their limits, and they also know what to seek. Knowing what you do not know pushes you to learn that skill or find that information. It develops an attitude of continuous learning.

15. They challenge the status quo with logic

As I mentioned before, innovation requires the ability and willingness to challenge the status quo. However, there is a major difference between being a rebel for its sake and being pragmatic with logic. It can be slightly tricky to test it out when you are in the hiring process, mainly because everyone wants to show their best-case persona in the hiring process. These nuances are easy to miss.

16. They are modest about achievements

This one is a bit odd. In any hiring process, both parties want to highlight their achievements and boost their advantage as much as possible. However, this is when you are most likely to